

APPELLES THE PAINTER, OR WHAT DO YOU DO IF YOU CANNOT PREDICT?*

You should charge people for advice—My two cents here—Nobody knows anything, but, at least, he knows it—Go to parties

ADVICE IS CHEAP, VERY CHEAP

It is not a good habit to stuff one's text with quotations from prominent thinkers, except to make fun of them or provide a historical reference. They "make sense," but well-sounding maxims force themselves on our gullibility and do not always stand up to empirical tests. So I chose the following statement by the überphilosopher Bertrand Russell precisely because I disagree with it.

The demand for certainty is one which is natural to man, but is nevertheless an intellectual vice. If you take your children for a picnic on a doubtful day, they will demand a dogmatic answer as to whether it will be fine or wet, and be disappointed in you when you cannot be sure. ...

But so long as men are not *trained* [emphasis mine] to withhold judgment in the absence of evidence, they will be led astray by cocksure prophets ... For the learning of every virtue there is an appropriate discipline, and for the learning of suspended judgment the best discipline is philosophy.

The reader may be surprised that I disagree. It is hard to disagree that the demand for certainty is an intellectual vice. It is hard to disagree that we can be led astray by some cocksure prophet. Where I beg to differ with the great man is that I do not believe in the track record of advice-giving "philosophy" in helping us deal with the problem; nor do I believe that virtues can be *easily* taught; nor do I urge people to strain in order to avoid making a judgment. Why? Because we have to deal with humans as humans. We cannot *teach* people to withhold judgment; judgments are embedded in the way we view objects. I do not see a "tree;" I see a pleasant or an ugly tree. It is not possible without great, paralyzing effort to strip these small values we attach to matters. Likewise, it is not possible to hold a situation in one's head without some element of bias. Something in our dear human nature makes us want to believe; so what?

Philosophers since Aristotle have taught us that we are deep-thinking animals, and that we can learn by reasoning. It took a while to discover that we do effectively think, but that we more readily narrate backward in order to give ourselves the illusion of understanding, and give a cover to our past